A Princess Wish

❄ Chapter One A Princess Wish

Once upon a time, in a beautiful kingdom in Nigeria, there lived a princess named Rosalina.

Princess Rosalina had a smile that could brighten a room, a laugh that made children giggle, and a heart that was always looking for someone to share it with.

Every year, on the night before Christmas, Rosalina had a special tradition.

She would slip quietly from the castle, walk into the garden, and sit beneath the twinkling stars.

And she would wait.

She was waiting for a shooting star.

Because Rosalina had a wish.

Tonight, she wrapped a soft shawl around her shoulders and settled beneath her favorite tree. The night air was warm, and the sounds of the village floated gently toward the castle.

She looked up.

One star.

Then another.

Then another.

“Please,” she whispered, “just one shooting star.”

She closed her eyes for a moment and imagined the person she hoped to meet someday.

Her soulmate.

In her imagination, he was handsome and strong, but gentle too. He made her laugh. He listened when she spoke. And when he stood beside her, Rosalina felt as though he had been there all her life.

She could almost feel his hand in hers.

Almost.

Then—

WHOOSH!

A bright streak of light raced across the sky.

Rosalina's eyes flew open.

“A shooting star!”

She quickly squeezed her eyes shut.

“I wish...” she whispered.

But what did she wish for?

Love.

Someone to share Christmas with.

Someone to laugh with.

Someone who would love her heart, not just her crown.

And most of all, someone who would make her feel that she was no longer alone.

Rosalina opened her eyes.

The shooting star had disappeared.

“Maybe this will be the year,” she whispered with a hopeful smile.

She hurried back toward the castle.

But when she opened the great wooden doors, her smile slowly faded.

The castle was quiet.

Too quiet.

Every year she decorated the castle herself.

Every year she hosted wonderful Christmas parties.

And every year, when Christmas morning arrived, she woke up alone.

She would open presents from her friends, the villagers, and people from the kingdom.

They were always kind.

But kindness wasn't quite the same as having someone special beside you.

Rosalina sighed.

“I wish Christmas didn't feel so lonely.”

She climbed the grand staircase toward her bedroom.

Rosalina was the only child of the kingdom's royal family. Her mother and father were gone now, and she missed them terribly.

The people of the kingdom loved their princess.

They wanted to see her happy.

They dreamed of the day she would find her prince, fall in love, and perhaps one day have children of her own.

But Rosalina didn't want to marry simply because everyone expected her to.

She wanted something more.

She wanted the kind of love she had imagined beneath the stars.

The kind of love that felt like coming home.

As Rosalina climbed into bed, she looked out her window one last time.

The moon shone brightly over the kingdom.

❄ Chapter Two Time to Start Decorating

The next morning, just as the sun was beginning to peek through the curtains, Princess Rosalina was fast asleep.

She was dreaming about Christmas trees, twinkling lights, and, of course, her handsome prince.

Suddenly—

“WAKE UP!”

Rosalina jumped.

“Ahhh!”

She sat straight up in bed.

Standing beside her was Wendy, her faithful servant and very best friend, with her hands on her hips and the biggest smile on her face.

“Come on! Come on! Wake up!” Wendy shouted. “We have lots to do today!”

Rosalina groaned and pulled the blankets over her head.

“Go away, Wendy.”

“No.”

“Please?”

“Nope.”

“Just five more minutes?”

“Absolutely not.”

Rosalina peeked out from underneath the blankets.

“Why not?”

“Because,” Wendy announced, “we are going to decorate this castle in style!”

Rosalina disappeared beneath the blankets again.

Wendy pulled them down.

“What will our theme be this year, my princess?”

“I don't care.”

“Wonderful!”

“I said I don't care.”

“Even better!”

Rosalina frowned.

“Wendy, I don't think you heard me.”

“Oh, I heard you perfectly.”

Rosalina pulled the blanket over her head again.

“I'll never find my prince.”

Wendy folded her arms.

“You're absolutely right.”

Rosalina froze.

Slowly, she lowered the blanket.

“You believe me?”

“Of course,” Wendy said.

Rosalina's face fell.

Wendy smiled.

“You're never going to find your prince while you're hiding under a blanket!”

Rosalina stared at her.

Then she burst out laughing.

“Wendy!”

“What?” Wendy asked innocently.

“You tricked me!”

“Perhaps.”

Rosalina grabbed the blanket and pulled it back over her head.

Wendy grabbed the other end.

“Oh no, you don't!”

“Give it back!”

“No!”

“Wendy!”

“Out of bed, Princess Rosalina!”

Wendy gave the blanket one big tug.

Rosalina came sliding right out of bed and landed on the floor with a soft **thump!**

For a moment, they both stared at each other.

Then Wendy started laughing.

Rosalina tried very hard not to laugh.

She failed.

Soon both of them were giggling.

“All right,” Rosalina said, climbing back onto her feet. “You win.”

“I always win.”

“You certainly think you do.”

“I know I do.”

Rosalina shook her head.

“You're impossible.”

“And you are hiding under blankets instead of helping me decorate.”

Wendy pointed toward the enormous Christmas tree waiting in the corner of the room.

“This year, we're going bigger than ever!”

Rosalina smiled.

“Really?”

“Really!”

“What do you have planned?”

Wendy's eyes sparkled.

“Crystalline hearts!”

Rosalina raised an eyebrow.

“And bells!”

“Of course.”

“And lights!”

“Lots of lights.”

“How many?”

Wendy thought for a moment.

“All of them.”

Rosalina laughed.

“All of them?”

“All of them!”

Wendy grabbed a notebook and began making a list.

“We'll have colorful lights throughout the castle. Red, white, pink, blue, gold—every color we can find!”

Rosalina's eyes grew wider.

“And holly?”

“Everywhere!”

“A giant Christmas tree?”

“Right in the center of the courtyard.”

Rosalina clapped her hands.

“I love it!”

“And the tree will have pink and red crystalline hearts, blue bells, silver decorations, and sparkling lights.”

Wendy paused dramatically.

“And…”

Rosalina leaned closer.

“What?”

“A giant gingerbread house!”

“In the courtyard?”

“In the courtyard!”

Rosalina burst out laughing.

“Wendy, a gingerbread house doesn't belong in a courtyard!”

“Why not?”

“The birds will eat it!”

Wendy thought about that.

“Oh.”

They both looked at each other.

Then Wendy grinned.

“Then we'll make it big enough for the birds to have their own Christmas party!”

Rosalina laughed so hard she had to sit down.

“All right,” she said. “Let's do it.”

Wendy held out her hand.

“Deal?”

Rosalina took it.

“Deal.”

Wendy pulled her toward the door.

“Come on!”

“Wait! I haven't even changed!”

“You're a princess. You can change while you're walking.”

“Wendy!”

“What?”

“You are definitely not allowed to be in charge of the castle.”

Wendy smiled.

“Too late.”

And with that, the two friends hurried down the hallway, ready to turn the quiet castle into the most magical Christmas kingdom anyone had ever seen.

❄ Chapter Three Making Christmas Cards and Invitations

Princess Rosalina had been looking everywhere for Wendy. She had checked the kitchen.

No Wendy.

The courtyard?

No Wendy.

The great Christmas tree?

No Wendy.

Even the pantry!

Still no Wendy.

“Where could she be?” Rosalina wondered.

There was only one place left to look.

The library.

Rosalina pushed open the enormous wooden doors.

The library was bright and beautiful. Tall windows stretched almost from the floor all the way to the ceiling, letting the warm morning sunlight pour across the room.

And there, standing beside one of the windows, was Wendy.

Rosalina stopped.

She blinked.

Then she blinked again.

“Wendy?”

Wendy didn't answer.

She was far too busy.

She had taped a sheet of paper to the window. On top of it, she had placed a snowflake stencil.

Then she picked up a stylus and carefully began tracing around the snowflake.

Rosalina watched for a few seconds.

“Wendy?”

“Yes?”

“What are you doing?”

“Making Christmas cards.”

“Ah.”

Wendy pressed harder with the stylus.

“Something isn't right.”

Rosalina smiled.

“What seems to be the problem?”

Wendy held up her card.

There wasn't much of a snowflake on it.

There was more of a strange collection of lines.

“Why isn't the snowflake showing up?”

Rosalina burst out laughing.

Wendy turned around.

“This isn't funny!”

“Oh, it is a little funny.”

Wendy put her hands on her hips.

“Well, if you're so clever, tell me what I'm doing wrong!”

Rosalina walked over and looked at the window.

“Well, for starters…”

Wendy waited.

“You taped the card stock to the window first.”

“Yes.”

“And then you put the stencil on top of it.”

“Yes.”

“And now you're trying to emboss the snowflake.”

“Yes!”

Rosalina pointed at the window.

“The stencil is supposed to be taped to the window first.”

Wendy stared at the stencil.

Then she stared at the card.

Then she stared at Rosalina.

“Why didn't you tell me that before?”

Rosalina giggled.

“Because I didn't know.”

Wendy's mouth dropped open.

“You didn't know?”

“No.”

“Then how did you know I was doing it wrong?”

“I remembered reading the instructions.”

Wendy sighed.

“Of course, you did.”

Rosalina looked down.

There were cards scattered all over the floor.

She picked one up.

Another strange-looking snowflake.

She picked up another.

Another strange-looking snowflake.

And another.

Rosalina looked at Wendy.

“How many cards have you made?”

Wendy looked away.

“That's not important.”

Rosalina smiled.

“How many?”

“Twenty-seven.”

“Twenty-seven?”

“Maybe thirty.”

Rosalina started laughing.

“Wendy!”

“Stop laughing!”

“I can't!”

Wendy crossed her arms.

“Fine. Laugh all you want.”

Then Rosalina noticed a large bag sitting on the table.

“What else have you got in there?”

Wendy's face suddenly brightened.

“Now you're going to see!”

She hurried over and began pulling out stencils.

“One Christmas tree!”

She held it up.

“One snowman!”

Another one.

“An angel!”

Another.

“A gingerbread house!”

Another.

“A gingerbread man!”

Another.

“A candy cane!”

Another.

“And finally…”

Wendy reached deep into the bag.

She pulled out one last stencil.

“The Bethlehem star!”

Rosalina looked at the collection.

“Is that everything?”

Wendy looked back into the bag.

She turned it upside down.

Nothing.

She shook it.

Still nothing.

She reached inside and searched again.

“Nope. That's all of them.”

Rosalina started laughing.

“Let me guess. You bought every Christmas stencil they had in the store!”

Wendy sighed.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“I wanted to try them all and see which one made the prettiest embossing for the Christmas cards and invitations.”

Rosalina smiled.

“Well, at least you came prepared.”

“Prepared?”

Wendy pointed at the mountain of failed cards.

“I came prepared to make a lot of mistakes.”

They both laughed.

Then Rosalina picked up the snowflake stencil.

“Why are you still using the snowflake?”

Wendy frowned.

“Because I haven't figured it out yet.”

“But you've already tried it how many times?”

Wendy counted on her fingers.

“Twenty-seven.”

Rosalina raised an eyebrow.

“Didn't you think it might be time to try another one?”

Wendy frowned.

“Go ahead. Have your little laugh.”

Rosalina giggled.

“Well, you have to admit, you've been trying the same thing over and over again.”

Wendy shook her head.

“You know, Princess, you weren't exactly perfect with the Christmas lights yesterday.”

Rosalina stopped laughing.

“What do you mean?”

Wendy smiled.

“Remember that one light bulb you kept putting into the Christmas lights?”

Rosalina thought for a moment.

“Oh…”

“The one that didn't work?”

Rosalina covered her face.

“Yes.”

“You kept taking it out and putting it back in.”

“I thought maybe it would work the next time.”

Wendy burst out laughing.

“And did it?”

“No.”

“Did I laugh at you?”

Rosalina shook her head.

“No.”

“What did I do?”

“You gave me another bulb.”

“And what happened?”

Rosalina smiled.

“The lights worked.”

“Exactly.”

Wendy picked up one of the failed cards and looked at it.

“So perhaps you shouldn't laugh too hard at me.”

Rosalina looked at the card in Wendy's hand.

Then she looked at Wendy.

“You're right.”

Wendy grinned.

“Besides, I didn't make fun of you because I knew you were getting frustrated.”

Rosalina smiled.

“That was very kind of you.”

“I know.”

Rosalina laughed.

“You really do think you're wonderful, don't you?”

“I don't think it. I know it.”

They both giggled.

Rosalina looked at the pile of crooked snowflakes on the table.

“I'm sorry, Wendy. I was teasing you when I should have been helping you.”

Wendy put her arm around Rosalina.

“And now you can help me.”

Rosalina smiled.

“Deal.”

“Good.”

Wendy handed her the snowflake stencil.

“Now, let's see if we can figure this thing out before I have to buy the entire paper shop.”

Rosalina laughed.

“That's probably a good idea.”

Together, they decided to try every stencil.

The Christmas tree looked pretty.

The snowman was cute.

The gingerbread man, made Rosalina hungry.

The candy cane looked cheerful.

The angel was beautiful.

And the Bethlehem star was magnificent.

But when they finally tried the snowflake the right way, something wonderful happened.

The delicate snowflake appeared beautifully raised on the card.

Rosalina held it up to the sunlight.

“Oh, Wendy!”

Wendy smiled proudly.

“Now that is a Christmas card!”

They tried another one.

Then another.

And another.

Soon the library table was covered with beautiful embossed Christmas cards and invitations.

After much arguing, laughing, experimenting, and quite a few mistakes, they finally agreed.

The **snowflake** was their favorite.

“It looks elegant,” Rosalina said.

“And festive,” Wendy added.

“And it doesn't make me hungry,” Rosalina said.

Wendy laughed.

“You were thinking about eating the gingerbread man, weren't you?”

“Maybe.”

By the end of the afternoon, they had used almost all of their card stock.

Wendy looked at the empty pile.

“Oh dear.”

Rosalina looked at her.

“What?”

“We need more paper.”

Rosalina smiled.

“Back to the store?”

Wendy sighed.

“Back to the store.”

They looked at the floor covered with their practice cards.

Then they looked at each other.

And once again, they burst out laughing.

Christmas was going to be a lot of work.

But somehow, Rosalina thought it was already becoming the best Christmas she had ever had.

❄ Chapter Four Guests Arrive at the Castle

The day of the Christmas party finally arrived.

As the first guests approached the castle gates, they could see the lights sparkling from far away.

Red lights blinked.

Blue lights twinkled.

Golden lights shimmered.

Green lights danced among the trees.

The entire castle seemed to glow against the evening sky.

“Look!” one little girl shouted.

“It looks like a fairy-tale castle!”

And she wasn't the only one who thought so.

Inside the courtyard, there was even more to see.

Princess Rosalina and Wendy had decorated every tree and shrub with colorful Christmas lights.

But the biggest attraction was the gingerbread village.

It looked like a tiny Christmas town had appeared right in the middle of the courtyard!

There were little houses covered in candy-colored decorations.

There was a town square with a Christmas tree in the center.

Tiny figures walked along the streets carrying baskets of food.

Some were shopping for Christmas presents.

Others were carrying food to their neighbors.

And some of the little figures were giving each other hugs or holding hands.

“It looks just like a real village!” one of the guests exclaimed.

Rosalina smiled.

“That was the idea.”

Wendy stood beside her proudly.

“I may have gone a little overboard.”

“A little?” Rosalina teased.

Wendy grinned.

“Perhaps.”

As the guests continued toward the castle, they followed a walkway lined with enormous colorful candy canes.

At the castle doors stood two tall nutcracker soldiers.

They looked so serious that one little boy stopped and stared at them.

“Do they talk?” he whispered.

Wendy leaned toward him.

“Only when no one is looking.”

The boy's eyes grew enormous.

“Really?”

Rosalina covered her mouth to hide her laughter.

“Wendy!”

“What?” Wendy said innocently.

Soon everyone was laughing.

Rosalina and Wendy welcomed their guests into the castle.

As everyone entered the grand foyer, they stopped in amazement.

There, reaching almost all the way to the ceiling, stood the biggest Christmas tree anyone in the kingdom had ever seen.

It was covered in sparkling lights, silver decorations, red and pink crystalline hearts, and beautiful blue bells.

The stairway curved around one side of the enormous tree, making it look even more magnificent.

One guest stared at it for several moments.

“This has to be the most beautiful Christmas tree we have ever seen!”

Another guest smiled.

“You say that every year.”

Rosalina quickly turned away so no one would see her giggling.

As the guests placed their presents beneath the tree, one of the villagers looked up at the

enormous branches.

Then he looked toward the castle doors.

Then back at the tree.

Finally, he asked the question everyone had been wondering.

“Princess Rosalina, how in the world did you get that enormous tree through those doors?”

Everyone laughed.

Rosalina smiled.

“Well, it happened like this…”

Immediately, several guests gathered around.

Even the children came closer.

Wendy folded her arms and smiled.

“Oh, here we go.”

Rosalina pointed toward the enormous tree.

“Wendy wanted a very big tree. She wanted one that would reach almost from the floor to the ceiling.”

“It was my idea,” Wendy announced proudly.

Rosalina laughed.

“Yes, it was.”

“The ceiling in this room is almost twenty feet high,” Rosalina continued. “And because the staircase curves around half of the tree, we wanted something really spectacular.”

She paused.

“But when the men brought the tree into the castle, it didn't look anything like this.”

“What did it look like?” a little girl asked.

Rosalina smiled.

“It looked like a giant green stick!”

Everyone laughed.

“The tree was tightly wrapped so that the men could carry it through the castle doors. Once they stood it upright and secured it in the tree stand, they told Wendy and me to stand near the doorway.”

Rosalina pointed toward the front doors.

“They tied a very long rope around the tree. The rope stretched all the way from the tree to where Wendy and I were standing.”

The children leaned closer.

“And then…”

Rosalina paused dramatically.

“They pulled!”

Everyone waited.

“And then—”

“**WHOOSH!**”

Rosalina threw her hands into the air.

“The branches sprang out in every direction!”

The children burst into laughter.

“If anyone had been standing close to the tree, they might have been knocked over!”

Wendy nodded.

“I nearly lost my hat.”

“You weren't wearing a hat,” Rosalina reminded her.

Wendy smiled.

“That is how close I came to losing it.”

Everyone laughed again.

But then Rosalina's smile softened.

“Unfortunately, something else happened.”

She looked toward an empty place near the fireplace.

“My mother's favorite vase was broken.”

The room grew quiet.

Rosalina continued.

“My father had repaired that vase many times during their marriage.”

She smiled softly at the memory.

“My mother would sometimes become very angry with my father. When she did, she would grab that vase and smash it.”

The children listened carefully.

“But my father never gave up on it.”

Rosalina looked down at her hands.

“He would gather every broken piece. Then he would carefully grind the pieces into powder and mix them with fresh clay. Slowly, patiently, he would rebuild the vase.”

She smiled.

“When it was perfect again, he would give it back to my mother.”

A little girl asked, “Why did he keep fixing it?”

Rosalina looked at her.

“Because he believed that some things can be repaired with enough love, patience, and care.”

The room became very quiet.

Then Rosalina smiled.

“I think that was my father's way of reminding my mother that love doesn't give up easily.”

Standing near the back of the room was a handsome young man Rosalina had never met before.

He had listened to every word.

And something about her story touched his heart.

He looked toward the empty place where the vase had once stood.

He quietly made a decision.

Someday, he would find those broken pieces.

And if he could, he would repair the vase for Princess Rosalina.

He didn't know why he felt so strongly about it.

But something inside him told him it was important.

Suddenly, a little boy raised his hand.

Rosalina smiled.

“Yes?”

“If the branches went everywhere, where are they now?”

Everyone laughed.

Rosalina bent down so she was eye-to-eye with him.

“Well, I had the men trim the branches.”

The boy looked up at the enormous tree.

“They did a wonderful job.”

Then he gave Rosalina a big hug.

“It is perfect!”

Rosalina hugged him back.

“Thank you.”

She took his hand.

“Now, how about some samosas?”

The little boy's eyes lit up.

“Yes!”

Rosalina led everyone toward the enormous dining table.

There was food everywhere!

Great bowls of jollof rice.

Platters of crispy fried chicken.

Piles of pounded yam.

Fresh vegetables.

Hot, steaming vegetable soup.

And, of course, delicious samosas.

The guests ate until their bellies were full.

The children laughed.

The grown-ups talked.

And everywhere Rosalina looked, people were smiling.

After dinner came the games.

Then came the Christmas songs.

And then came the dancing!

Music filled the castle.

Children danced in circles.

Adults clapped along.

Wendy was dancing so enthusiastically that Rosalina couldn't stop laughing.

Then a stranger walked up to Wendy.

“May I have this dance?”

Wendy didn't hesitate for even one second.

She grabbed his hand.

“Come on!”

And before Rosalina knew what was happening, Wendy had dragged the poor man straight onto the dance floor.

Rosalina laughed.

“Wendy!”

But then someone else approached her.

A handsome young man stood before the princess.

He smiled.

“May I dance with the princess?”

Rosalina was just about to say no.

Then she remembered her Christmas wish.

She looked at him.

She smiled.

And she placed her hand in his.

“I would love to dance with you.”

The music began.

They danced.

And danced.

And danced.

For the first time that Christmas, Rosalina wasn't thinking about being alone.

She was simply enjoying the moment.

She didn't know it yet, but perhaps her Christmas wish was beginning to come true.

Much later that evening, Father Christmas arrived.

The children cheered as he entered the castle carrying a great sack filled with presents.

“Merry Christmas!”

“Merry Christmas!” everyone shouted.

Father Christmas handed out gifts to the children and the grown-ups.

There was laughter everywhere.

When the last present had been opened, the guests began saying their goodbyes.

They left the castle with full bellies, happy hearts, and wonderful memories to take home.

Rosalina stood at the castle doors watching them leave.

Wendy came to stand beside her.

“What a night.”

Rosalina smiled.

“Yes.”

She looked back at the sparkling castle.

For some reason, she couldn't stop thinking about the handsome young man who had asked her to dance.

And somewhere in the crowd heading home, that same young man was thinking about the princess.

He was also thinking about an old broken vase.

And he had already decided what he was going to do next.

❁ Chapter Five the Prince Introduces Himself

It was very early on Christmas morning.

The sun had barely begun to peek over the rooftops when—

Knock! Knock! Knock!

Rosalina looked up.

“Who could that be?”

She was already dressed in her beautiful clothes for Christmas morning Mass.

Another knock sounded.

Knock! Knock!

“I’m coming!”

Rosalina hurried down the staircase and opened the great castle door.

And there he was.

The handsome young man who had danced with her all night.

For a moment, Rosalina forgot what she was going to say.

Her heart gave a little flutter.

She felt butterflies dancing around in her stomach.

The young man bowed gracefully.

“Good morning, Princess Rosalina.”

“Good morning.”

“I didn't get the chance to introduce myself last night.”

He smiled.

“My name is Prince David.”

Rosalina's eyes widened.

“A prince?”

David chuckled.

“Yes. A real one.”

Rosalina laughed.

“I suppose I should have guessed.”

David smiled.

“I came to ask if you would join me for Christmas morning Mass.”

Rosalina's face lit up.

She was delighted to discover that the handsome man she had danced with was actually a prince.

And even more delighted that he wanted to spend more time with her.

“I would love to.”

Then she hesitated.

“Would you mind waiting just a few minutes? I need to get Wendy.”

David smiled.

“Of course.”

Then he bowed again.

“How lucky I am to have two beautiful women accompanying me to Christmas Mass.”

Rosalina blushed.

“You certainly know how to flatter a princess.”

David smiled.

“I was only telling the truth.”

Rosalina hurried inside.

“Wendy!”

There was no answer.

“Wendy!”

Still nothing.

Rosalina raced upstairs.

“Wendy! Wake up!”

A sleepy voice came from behind the bedroom door.

“I'm awake.”

“You are not.”

“I am.”

“You're talking with your eyes closed.”

Wendy opened one eye.

“Who is at the door?”

“Prince David.”

Both of Wendy's eyes opened immediately.

“Prince David?”

“Yes!”

“The prince?”

“Yes!”

“The handsome one?”

Rosalina laughed.

“Yes, Wendy. The very same one.”

Wendy jumped out of bed.

“Well, what are we waiting for?”

A few minutes later, the three of them set off toward the village.

As they walked down the road, people began joining them.

One villager walked beside them.

Then another.

Then another.

Soon there were people walking all around them.

Some whispered excitedly.

“Is that the prince?”

“I think so!”

“Look at Princess Rosalina!”

Before long, the crowd had become so large that Rosalina and David were walking very close together.

Wendy looked at them.

Then she smiled.

She didn't say a word.

She didn't need to.

Rosalina noticed and gave Wendy a playful look.

Wendy simply winked.

When they reached the church, everyone settled in for Christmas morning Mass.

After the service, several villagers came to Rosalina.

“Thank you for the wonderful Christmas celebration, Princess.”

“It was beautiful.”

“We had such a wonderful time.”

Rosalina smiled warmly.

“I'm so happy you enjoyed it.”

Then she turned toward Prince David.

“Why don't you come back to the castle with us?”

David smiled.

“I would be delighted.”

“We have presents to open,” Rosalina continued. “And we could really use another pair of hands.”

David laughed.

“I think I can manage that.”

When they returned to the castle, the three of them went straight to the enormous Christmas tree.

The presents were still piled high beneath it.

David looked at the mountain of gifts.

“I think you may have underestimated how many hands you'll need.”

Wendy laughed.

“That's why we brought you.”

David picked up a present.

“All right. Where do I begin?”

Rosalina smiled.

“Right there.”

The three of them sat beside the tree.

David acted as though he had been part of their Christmas tradition forever.

He opened one present.

Then another.

Then another.

There were toys.

Books.

Clothes.

Games.

Beautiful handmade gifts.

Every present brought smiles and laughter.

At one point, David opened a package and looked inside.

“What is this?”

Wendy leaned over.

“A surprise.”

David looked at Rosalina.

“Should I be worried?”

Rosalina laughed.

“Probably.”

They all laughed.

When every present had finally been opened, Rosalina carefully looked through her gifts.

She selected the ones that were especially meaningful to her.

Then she looked at the rest.

“Let's wrap these back up.”

David looked surprised.

“Wrap them again?”

“Yes.”

“For what?”

Rosalina smiled.

“For people who need them more than I do.”

She explained that the gifts would be delivered to families living beyond the village walls.

Then she and Wendy gathered the leftover food from the Christmas celebration.

There was plenty of it.

They carefully packed the food into containers.

Soon there were packages of gifts and food ready to be delivered.

Rosalina looked at David.

“Would you be so kind as to take us to the people beyond the village walls?”

David smiled.

“I would be honored.”

Wendy looked at Rosalina.

“I think I'll stay here.”

Rosalina raised an eyebrow.

“You are?”

“Yes.”

Wendy smiled.

“I'll have dinner waiting for the two of you when you return.”

Rosalina grinned.

She leaned over and kissed Wendy on the cheek.

“Thank you, Wendy.”

Then she turned toward David.

“Well…”

She smiled.

“It's just us.”

David blushed.

“I am quite delighted to have you all to myself.”

Rosalina smiled.

“And perhaps you can get to know me a little better.”

“I would like that very much.”

With Wendy's help, they loaded all the packages and food onto an open cart.

David tied the royal horse securely to the cart.

Then he helped Rosalina climb onto the seat beside him.

With a gentle snap of the reins, they were off.

Through the quiet village they traveled.

The streets were peaceful.

The houses were quiet.

Everyone seemed to be enjoying the calm of Christmas morning.

Soon they reached the great wall surrounding the village.

Beyond it, a large group of people was waiting.

They had heard that Princess Rosalina was coming.

David helped Rosalina down from the cart.

Together, they began handing out the gifts.

Food went to families.

Warm clothes went to children.

Toys went to little ones who had very little.

The smiles grew wider with every gift.

Some people laughed.

Some hugged Rosalina.

And some became so emotional that tears rolled down their cheeks.

“Thank you, Princess.”

“Thank you so much.”

Rosalina smiled.

“You are very welcome.”

David watched quietly.

He had never seen anyone give so freely.

He looked at Rosalina with admiration.

She wasn't giving because she wanted praise.

She was giving because she cared.

When the last gift had been handed out and the last package of food had been delivered, the people slowly began walking home.

They carried their gifts.

They carried their food.

But most of all, they carried happy hearts.

Rosalina watched them leave.

Then she turned to David.

“It's better to give than to receive.”

David smiled.

“There is certainly more joy in giving.”

He gently placed his arm around Rosalina's shoulders.

“You are absolutely right, my dear.”

Rosalina smiled.

David helped her back onto the cart.

As they made their way home, something wonderful had happened.

The village had come alive.

The Christmas lights were glowing everywhere!

Lights covered the houses.

Lights crossed the streets.

Lights decorated the shops.

Red, green, blue, gold, and white lights sparkled all around them.

Rosalina looked around in amazement.

“It looks magical.”

David smiled.

“It reminds me of something.”

“What?”

“The little gingerbread village in your courtyard.”

Rosalina laughed.

“You're right!”

She looked at him.

“You noticed that?”

“I noticed quite a lot last night.”

Rosalina felt the butterflies return to her stomach.

She quickly looked away.

When they finally reached the castle, they could smell something delicious before they even reached the door.

Rosalina's stomach rumbled.

David laughed.

“I think someone is hungry.”

“I am not.”

Her stomach rumbled again.

David laughed even harder.

Rosalina giggled.

“All right. Perhaps I am.”

They opened the castle doors.

The wonderful smell of roasted chicken filled the air.

There were vegetables, potatoes, warm bread, and all the delicious trimmings waiting on the table.

Wendy stood proudly beside the feast.

“Dinner is served!”

Rosalina smiled.

David looked at the table.

“This may be the best Christmas I've ever had.”

Rosalina looked at Wendy.

Then she looked at David.

And for the first time in a very long time, she realized something.

Christmas didn't feel lonely anymore.

It felt like the beginning of something wonderful.

Chapter Six

The Proposal and Wedding Ceremony

It was New Year’s Eve, and Rosalina and Prince David had made plans to celebrate with everyone in the village.

The streets were decorated with lights, music filled the air, and long tables were set up for the celebration. There were drinks on one side and food on the other.

Rosalina spotted the food.

Her eyes grew wide.

“Oh!” she exclaimed.

Before Prince David could ask what was wrong, Rosalina grabbed his hand.

“Come on! Hurry!”

She took off toward the food table, pulling the prince behind her.

“Rosalina, wait!” David laughed, trying his best to keep up.

But Rosalina was on a very important mission.

“My favorite food is over there, and if we don't get some now, it will all be gone!”

She suddenly stopped.

David, who had not been expecting her to stop so quickly, ran right into her.

“Oof!”

They both burst out laughing.

Rosalina turned toward the table and immediately picked up a warm puff-puff.

She held it up to Prince David's mouth.

“Try this.”

David took a bite.

His eyes widened.

“Mmm!”

He chewed slowly, then smiled.

“You were right. These are delicious.”

Rosalina grinned.

“I told you!”

“So, these are your favorites?”

“Yes!”

Rosalina grabbed a handful and happily took a bite.

David laughed.

“If you want more, you better get yours now.”

Rosalina looked at him.

“These are mine.”

“All of them?”

“Yes.”

David raised an eyebrow.

“You mean to tell me you are not going to share even one with me?”

Rosalina looked around to make sure no one was listening.

Then she leaned toward him and whispered,

“That is why I told you to get your own.”

David started laughing.

“You are serious!”

“Very serious.”

Being playful, David reached toward one of Rosalina's puff-puffs.

Before he could touch it—

SMACK!

Rosalina slapped his hand away.

They both froze.

Rosalina's eyes grew enormous.

“Oh! I'm so sorry!”

She covered her face.

“That was an automatic response!”

David rubbed his hand and tried very hard not to laugh.

“It is quite all right. I know better now than to take a princess's puff-puff.”

He grabbed a handful of his own.

Then he looked at Rosalina with a grin.

“But if you want more, I will share mine with you.”

Rosalina's heart melted.

That was one of the sweetest things anyone had ever said to her.

She quickly kissed him on the cheek.

David stood perfectly still.

Then he gently touched the spot where she had kissed him and smiled.

Rosalina giggled.

“Come on. Let's get something to drink.”

They walked over to the drinks table.

David pointed to a large container.

“Would you like some kunu?”

Rosalina shook her head.

“That one is for later. We need something to keep us awake until midnight.”

David laughed.

“You have planned everything, haven't you?”

“Of course!”

She pointed toward the other drinks.

“Come on. Let's get some Chapman and zobo.”

As the evening continued, music filled the village.

People danced.

Children ran and played.

The tables stayed full of delicious food, and laughter seemed to come from every corner of the

village.

Rosalina danced with Wendy.

Then Wendy danced with some of the women.

Then everyone seemed to be dancing with everyone else.

Prince David watched Rosalina with a smile.

She looked happier than he had ever seen her.

Finally, the clock moved closer to midnight.

Everyone gathered together.

“Ten!”

“Nine!”

“Eight!”

“Seven!”

“Six!”

“Five!”

“Four!”

“Three!”

“Two!”

“One!”

“**HAPPY NEW YEAR!**”

Everyone shouted and cheered.

Music burst into the night.

People hugged one another.

And before Rosalina could even turn around, Prince David gently took her into his arms and

gave her, her first kiss of the new year.

Rosalina's eyes widened in surprise.

Then she smiled and kissed him back.

When they pulled apart, both of them were smiling.

Just then, Wendy appeared.

She was carrying a small box.

She handed it to Rosalina.

“This is from the prince.”

Wendy looked at David and gave him a knowing smile.

Rosalina looked from Wendy to David.

“What is this?”

“You'll have to open it to find out,” David said.

Rosalina carefully lifted the lid.

Then she stopped.

Her eyes filled with tears.

Inside was something she never thought she would see again.

Her mother's favorite vase.

It was completely restored.

Every broken piece had been carefully repaired.

It looked almost exactly as it had when her mother had first owned it.

Rosalina gently lifted it from the box.

“My mother's vase…”

David stepped closer.

Then, before Rosalina could say another word, Prince David slowly went down on one knee.

The villagers noticed.

One by one, they gathered around.

David looked into Rosalina's eyes.

“I promised myself that if I ever had the chance to love you, I would remember what your father taught you about love.”

He took her hand.

“I promise that, just as your father promised your mother, I will always do my best to repair what is broken. I will give patience when patience is needed. I will give care when care is needed.”

He smiled.

“And I will always love you.”

Then he took a breath.

“Rosalina, will you please be my queen, and allow me to be your king?”

For one tiny moment, everything was quiet.

Then—

“**YES!**”

The entire village erupted.

Rosalina laughed through her tears.

She looked around at all the smiling faces.

Then she looked back at David.

She lifted the vase carefully.

“My mother's favorite vase has come home.”

She wrapped her arms around Prince David and gave him a big kiss.

David smiled.

“Is that a, yes?”

Rosalina looked at the crowd.

“I would say we got more than a thousand yeses!”

Everyone laughed and cheered.

Wendy rushed forward and hugged them both.

“Wonderful!”

She stepped back and clapped her hands.

“Now we have a wedding to prepare for!”

The celebration became even louder.

Everyone was excited.

Their princess was going to be married.

And their village would soon have a king and, one day, perhaps heirs to the throne.

But more than anything, they were happy because Rosalina was no longer alone.

She had found love.

She had found a partner.

And she had found a family.

The Wedding Day

The very next day, the village was buzzing with excitement.

Women gathered together with Wendy to prepare the wedding feast.

There was cooking everywhere.

Pots bubbled.

People chopped vegetables.

Others carried trays of food.

And, of course, Wendy was in the middle of everything.

“Careful!” she called.

“Don't burn that!”

“Where are the plates?”

“Who moved the spoons?”

Then she stopped and looked around.

“Never mind. I found them!”

The wedding was going to be a very busy day.

To Rosalina's surprise, her wedding dress had already been chosen.

It was beautiful.

The dress was filled with wonderful colors—green, teal, purple, and sky blue.

Prince David wore an outfit with colors that beautifully complemented Rosalina's dress.

When Wendy saw them standing together, she smiled.

“You two look like you were made for each other.”

Rosalina blushed.

David smiled.

Then Wendy handed each of them a small box.

Rosalina opened hers.

Inside were the beautiful coral beads that had belonged to her mother.

David opened his.

Inside were the coral beads that had belonged to Rosalina's father.

For a moment, Rosalina could not speak.

David carefully put on the beads that had belonged to her father.

Then he helped Wendy place Rosalina's mother's coral beads around Rosalina's neck.

Tears filled Rosalina's eyes.

“My parents would be so happy to have you as their son,” she said softly.

She touched the beads.

“These mean so much to me.”

Then she looked around at the people preparing for the wedding.

“My parents are gone, but all of you became my family when they died.”

David gently kissed her cheek.

“Then let's go see our big family waiting for us.”

Rosalina smiled.

“Let's.”

They stepped outside.

The crowd immediately began to applaud and cheer.

Then came the sound of drums.

Several of the men from the village entered carrying talking drums.

The rhythm filled the air.

One of the village elders walked toward Prince David and handed him a talking drum.

David looked at it.

Then he looked at the elder.

The elder smiled.

David smiled back.

And soon he was playing along with the other men.

Rosalina began to dance.

Her dress moved beautifully as she twirled.

The women gathered around her and danced too.

The music grew louder.

The children laughed and danced.

Even some of the older villagers couldn't resist joining in.

When the talking drums finally quieted, the eldest man in the village stepped forward.

For this special moment, he would represent Rosalina's father and speak for the whole village.

Rosalina walked toward him and knelt respectfully before him.

The elder spoke to everyone about love, family, respect, and the joining of two people who would now share their lives together.

When he finished, he handed Rosalina a glass of palm wine.

Rosalina turned toward Prince David and gave it to him.

David accepted it and drank the palm wine.

Then he took Rosalina gently by the hand.

He led her to the front of all the guests.

And then something happened that made everyone become very quiet.

Prince David lowered himself to the ground.

He knelt on both knees and placed his forehead on the ground before Rosalina and her people.

It was his way of showing humility, respect, and honor to Rosalina and to the people she called her family.

Rosalina's eyes filled with tears again.

The villagers smiled proudly.

David stood.

Then, as if the quiet moment had never happened, the drums began again!

David joined the men and started dancing.

The women gathered around Rosalina.

Soon everyone was dancing.

Young and old.

Men and women.

Children and grandparents.

Everyone celebrated together.

The music continued late into the night.

The food was shared.

The laughter grew louder.

The dancing seemed to go on forever.

And somewhere in the middle of all the celebration, Rosalina looked around at the people she loved.

She thought about her parents.

She thought about the lonely Christmases she had spent wishing for someone to love.

She thought about the shooting star and the wish she had made so long ago.

And she realized something.

Her wish had come true in a way she never could have imagined.

She had wished for someone who would love her heart.

Someone who would stay.

Someone who would care.

And now she had Prince David.

But she had something else, too.

She had Wendy.

She had the people of her village.

She had a home filled with love.

And she had a family that had grown much bigger than she ever expected.

Rosalina smiled.

Prince David reached for her hand.

Together, they joined the dancing.

And that night, under the warm Nigerian sky, the princess and her prince celebrated with the people who had become their family.

They laughed.

They danced.

They loved.

And they lived happily ever after.

The End